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WORLD LIVER DAY

World Liver day is an annual event observed on 19th April and is dedicated to increasing awareness about importance of liver health. In India, 4 lakh people die annually due to liver related diseases. Nearly 20,000 people need liver transplantation in India for advanced liver diseases (10% of these are children), while we are performing 4000 liver transplants annually. With rising incidence of obesity and diabetes in adults and children, Indians are at a major risk for metabolic associated fatty liver disease, resulting in cirrhosis and liver cancer.

Q&A
Questions & Answers

Q: What's the theme of World Liver Day 2024?

This year, 2024, The World Liver Day theme is "*Be Vigilant, Get Regular Liver Check-Ups, and Prevent Fatty Liver Diseases*". Liver is essential organ that performs over 500 functions including processing of nutrients, filtering toxins, storage of glucose, vitamins, minerals , fats, synthesizing several important proteins, and improving immunity besides producing bile to digest fats.

Q: What is fatty liver disease? What does it lead to?

Fat is normally present in liver however if it is more than 5 to 10 percent of liver weight, then it is called fatty liver disease (FLD). Indians have a tendency to central obesity and one in 3 develops fatty liver disease. Inflammation sets in 20-30% of FLD resulting in fibrosis, cirrhosis and liver cancer. Co-morbidities associated with FLD include type 2 diabetes, hyperlipidemia, hypertension, and coronary artery disease. These liver disorders often produce no symptoms initially, thus are often missed and present more than a decade later in advanced stage. The disease progression depends of a combination of genetic and environmental factors. Therefore, it is extremely important for us to undergo 'Regular Liver Check-Ups' and nib the disease in early stages.

Q: Do we see fatty liver disease in children too?

Fatty liver disease in children could be related to multiple causes such viral hepatitis, several inborn errors of metabolism besides metabolic fatty liver disease related to overweight and obesity like in adults. One fifth of children globally are overweight and obese and at high risk for fatty liver disease. India is experiencing an alarming increase in obesity in children, recent statistics of 2020 reveal 12.5 million children are overweight and obese. The culprit is a change in the life style of our children with increase in screen time, reduced physical activity, increased consumption of processed high calorie junk foods. Evidence shows that 80% of obese adolescent children move on to be obese adults. It's high time for all of us to "Be Vigilant," prioritize healthcare, raise awareness, and promote preventive measures and safe guard the health of our children to ensure a bright future for generations to come. The focus lies on "*Preventing Fatty Liver Diseases*" .

Q: Can fatty liver disease be reversed?

Research suggests that losing weight is the single best way to reverse or control metabolic associated fatty liver diseases called NAFLD/MAFLD. A good goal is to loose 10% of your total body weight while even a 5% can start improving liver health. Weight reduction resulting from a healthy diet in association with exercise is more effective in improving liver health.

Q: You have been a pioneer in setting up liver transplantation in India . How has been your journey so far?

I pioneered the development of pediatric liver transplants and advanced pediatric liver care in our country and with humility and gratitude share that I have been decorated with prestigious 'Dr. B.C. Roy National Award' for the same. We run one of the busiest liver transplantation program in India and have trained several youngsters who now practice across the country, I feel my journey of setting pediatric liver transplants in India has been truly rewarding. However, I am extremely happy to share that my focus is equally on various community based projects such as obesity, fatty liver disease, anemia and nutritional issues in children etc. through various government and non profitable organizations like IMA and Indian Academy of Pediatrics (IAP). In fact this year theme of IAP is "*IAP Ki Baat Community Ke Sath*" where focus lies on raising mass awareness through pediatricians pan India.

Q: How to keep your liver healthy?

Maintain a healthy weight through a balanced diet rich in protein, fiber, and antioxidants and incorporate regular exercises into your routine to support overall health. Avoidance of processed foods, sugar sweetened beverages/ juices and fried foods is the way forward. Minimize stress levels, avoid alcohol, smoking, and drug abuse, refrain from self-medications and illicit substances. Vaccination against hepatitis is recommended, and it's crucial to take precautions to prevent the risk of exposure to unprotected sex and contaminated needles, particularly during body piercing, dental procedures, nail filing, tattooing, and in healthcare settings. I would like to re-emphasize this year's theme "*Be Vigilant, Get Regular Liver Check-Ups, and Prevent Fatty Liver Diseases*"